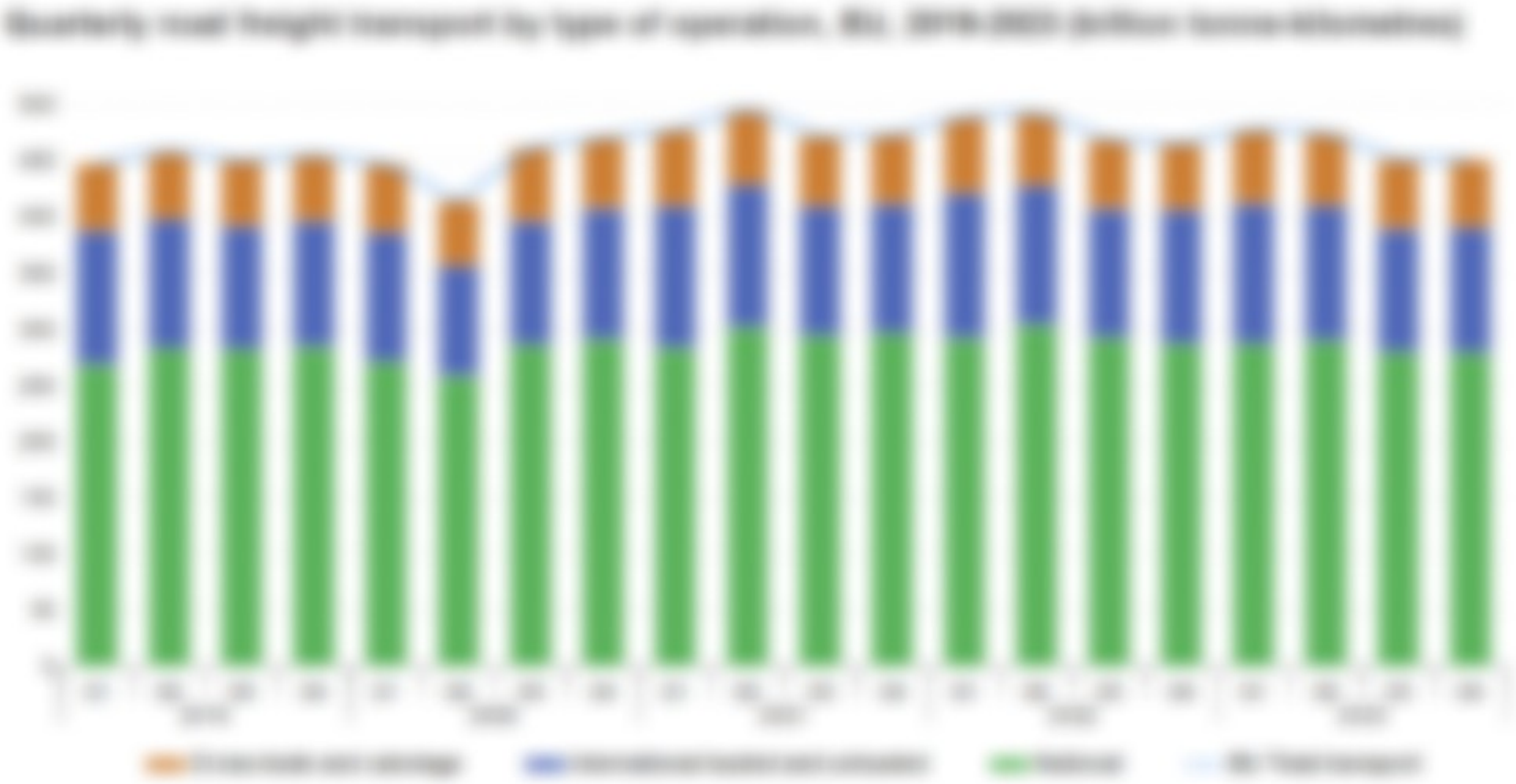
Trucking industry in Europe: landscape and driver's perspective

Semyon F., Nov 2024

Road freight transport in Europe

Around 40% of road freight operations involve international, cross-trade and cabotage.



Road freight industry disrupting trends

EU's Zero Emission Policy (decarbonization)

Zero-emission vehicles (ZEVs) were for 4.1% of all HDV sales in the 2024 Q2 compared with 1.27% in the 2024 Q1 [1].

"Rolling Highway" trains and ferries produce less emissions in comparison to the same length truck driving, while providing the drivers with extra rest [2].

EU mandating charging stations every 60 km along major transport routes [3].

Development of autonomous driving technologies

Tesla: self-driving cars won't replace truck drivers for at least 2-3 more decades. Source

Mobility Package (labor regulations evolution)

Mobility Package has been adopted in 2020. Despite, the debates on its statements continues [5]. After the most recent court, the Court of the European Union's **annulled the rule on the return of the vehicle**, but it confirmed the validity of all other contested provisions [6].

Load type metis

Containers can be 20, 30 and 40 feet, and in some cases 45 feet. Based on the type of transported goods, popular container configuration may evolve.

[1] Blog: Zero-emission vehicles in use in the mobility ecosystem: insights into uptake in EU member states
[2] Blog: Emissions of freight transport: Rail and inland waterway transport are more sustainable than road transport
[3] Blog: Emissions of freight transport: Rail and inland waterway transport are more sustainable than road transport
[4] Blog: Emissions of freight transport: Rail and inland waterway transport are more sustainable than road transport
[5] Blog: Mobility Package: Tachograph, posting of drivers, cabotage and rest periods
[6] Blog: Mobility Package: Tachograph, posting of drivers, cabotage and rest periods

Truck driver salary

There is a significant €5/hour gap between Eastern Europe (EE) and other countries. That might cause EE truck drivers to become international. Serbia and Croatia have implausibly low average hourly wages, even in comparison to other EE countries.

Source: [illegible]

Drivers and their needs (Reddit)

Category	Problem description (quotes)	# of opinions	Upvote rating
Compliance	BAG (Bundesamt für Güterverkehr) regulations (GER) are known to be enforced strictly "Digital tachograph weight be hard to use for a start" "Lot drivers blames and CDL can't be easily converted to EU" - it might take a few months to obtain one card Not getting a work visa as a truck driver (GER) "Learning language" (GER)	1 1 1 1 1	1 1 1 10 30
Physical and mental health	Western trucks are more comfortable to drive, Euro trucks are more comfortable to sleep in (US) "Employers to compensate for proper living (accomodation, food) conditions on the road" "Not enough amenities on the road" "Boredom and fear", "overthinking" "Finding a spot to sleep"	1 1 2 3 1	-10 4 5 11 21
Operations	"Finding parking spots", "Parking security" "Bad roads and get badly hands in here" (FIN) "Poor route planning" "Poorly maintained vehicles" "Much paperwork" "Physically demanding, unloading cages and pallets is hard" "Finding a bathroom, heading up until the next stop" "Seeing the different rules of the different shippers/receivers and the attitudes their staff give for not knowing them"	10 1 1 1 1 1 1 5 1	30 1 1 1 1 1 1 20 2
Getting a job - orders	Companies require experience while there are a lot of newcomers "Here is high competition for qualified trucker drivers"	3 4	11 16
Relationships management	"Is being a part time truck drive a realistic goal?" I have a wife and child, I refuse to be a full time truck driver" (US)	4	23

Source: Reddit discussions in r/Trucking and r/ukhousing